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Workshop

Become a File Ninja

No longer will you be bewildered when you encounter an exotic file type. Or be left befuddled when your Mac drive won't open on your laptop running Windows. This is your ultimate guide to becoming a file ninja

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In an ideal world, which might probably exist in some parallel universe, there would only be one operating system with one universal file type. People in this utopian world would exchange software and other files on pen drives and hard disks without the slightest consideration for OS and file system compatibility issues. Also, in that world, printers would work perfectly and people would eat "Breakfast food" all day.

Unfortunately, we live in a less than perfect world, where we have a number of different operating systems, file systems and file types. And more often than not, we'll encounter some problem related to incompatibility. So, what do you do when you encounter a Mac formatted pen drive on your Windows PC or a file type you have no idea how to open? Don't worry, we've got you covered. Read on, and hopefully by the end of this article you'll have become a file ninja, with your own arsenal of tools to slay any file related problem you may encounter.

Open various file types on different operating systems

There was a time in a not so recent past when Windows was the most popular operating system in the consumer market. Linux was used mainly by geeks, while Apple was restricted mainly to the "Apple fan boy club". However, all this has



Fuse can open ext partitions on OS X

changed in the past decade. Macbooks have become a lot more affordable and commonplace. The Linux community, meanwhile, has been working hard to make the OS more user friendly, and a number of distros including Ubuntu are making their mark in the mainstream market. Though this provides the user with a number of options to choose from, it also greases the wheels for incompatibility issues that the users end up facing – especially when it comes to the file systems being used by each OS.

Windows, OS X and Linux use completely different file systems. Windows has been using NTFS (New Technology File Systems), since the days of NT, while Linux has been using the ext standard for a long time with ext4 being the norm these days, and OS X uses HFS (Hierar-

chical File System) with HFS+ being its latest iteration. Each file system is incompatible with operating systems they're not meant for. There's another common file type which, even though outdated, is still commonly used. It's called "FAT32". Mostly used on external storage devices, it's one of those rare file systems supported by most devices (including Xbox, Playstation and the latest Full-HD LED TV you just bought) and operating systems in the market.

In the following paragraphs, we'll introduce you to a number of tools and tricks of the trade to access different file systems on all the platforms.

NTFS (Windows)

Windows' preferred file format, NTFS, has been part of its family since the first